Light and Hope

By Bethany Van Delft

INTRODUCTION

My daughter's beauty often takes my breath away: Sparkling green eyes that are the same color as her Daddy's, an enormous smile and a laugh so infectious that the hardest of hearts melt in response, whisper-soft hair that has just the slightest curl and she gives the best hugs – the ones that make your all warm and fuzzy inside. I love my daughter so much! But I didn't always feel this way . . . for a very long time, I was crying daily and desperately searching for . . .

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BETHANY: **(Pg 293-299)** I had a perfect pregnancy. I saw a maternal fetal specialist every week. And every week the doctor and nurses would gather around the ultrasound and look at the baby and say, "What a perfect baby. This is a miracle at your age."

I spent nine months wondering what this was going to be like. What was it going to be like to give birth? What was it going to be like to see this person I had been growing all this time? Especially-what was that rush of love that new mothers talk about? What was that going to be like? And of course, being a standup comedian, I relished the new market that motherhood was going to thrust me into. But most of all, the thought of leaving the house one day as the two of us and coming back home as a family filled me with wonder.

When the time came, they told us to prepare for a very long labor. But no, I pushed for twenty minutes. And Lucia Esperanza was born at 10:59 p.m. that evening.

They put her on my chest, and I soaked in this little person I'd been carrying around. I saw her little chin and her heart-shaped mouth, her button nose and her folded ears. I saw her almond eyes, and my heart stopped.

I asked my husband, Jayme, "Does she look like she has Down syndrome?" Instead of the rush of love, I felt a wave of fear and anxiety. They brought me to our recovery room, and

they took the baby to do some routine tests. My fear turned to panic, and I finally rang for the nurse, hysterical.

I was like, "Why is it taking so long? Is there something wrong? What is wrong with my baby? Can you bring her back to me?" She brought back the baby, but I was terrified.

The next day the pediatrician came in our room, and he said, "Congratulations! Your baby is perfect." It was such a relief. I could breathe again.

He said, "Her Apgar score was great." And her hearing was fine. And she had ten fingers and ten toes and . . . . he suspected that she had Down syndrome.

He gave us a packet with a number on a Post-it note on top for us to call. As he was leaving, he said, " You know now is the time to have these babies, what with all the research. I mean, some of them even read."

We spent our days in the hospital in the room with the door closed, and the shades pulled. At night Jayme slept in the single bed with me, behind me. And he held me really tight. I think he held me so tight so I wouldn't fall out of the bed from crying so hard.

It was confirmed. She had trisomy 21, which is three copies of her twenty-first chromosome instead of two. That first few weeks was just a blur of tears and forms and doctors' appointments and lists I made of all the things that were never going to happen now -- all the things that she would never do.

I slept on the couch with her for four months, with her skin on my skin, so she could feel loved. But every time I looked at her, all I thought is, Where is my baby? Whose baby is this? When do I get to see my baby?

I had begged Jayme to please let me change her name. Esperanza was my grandmother's name, and Lucia was just a cute reason to call her Lulu. Together it means light and hope. But I didn't call her Lucia. I didn't call her Lulu. I didn't call her anything, because she wasn't my baby.

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Jayme went back to work, and I was a wreck. I was pining for the little family that I thought we'd be, for the home that I thought we'd have.

I felt deeply, deeply ashamed that I wanted a baby at my age and didn't get the testing. But the tests come with a risk of miscarriage. And I had already had two miscarriages after the age of forty. I was terrified to have another miscarriage and maybe never have a baby. So Jayme and I told each other that, no matter what, this was our baby, and everything would be fine. But now I knew that, for me at least, that was not true.

I lay in bed at night with my stomach in knots, and the broken record playing in my head: I cannot do this. I am not cut out to be this kind of mother. I knew that no matter [what], she had to be cared for. She had to be raised. It wasn't her fault I felt the way I did. She didn't deserve to suffer for it.

Robot Bethany kicked in. I went to every conference, every workshop, every lecture about Down syndrome. I read so many books, and I went to every specialist appointment, and asked a hundred questions.

At night I'd watch YouTube videos of children with Down syndrome reciting the alphabet, or playing guitar, or driving a car, until I fell asleep.

I learned what sorts of activities could benefit children with Down syndrome. I took her to music classes . . . to swim classes . . . to the museum, to play groups, all with typical kids, as if that would make the world see her that way.

One mom said to me, "But why don't you have her with her own kind?"

I thought of Jim Crow, and I thought how separate is never equal. Only equal is equal. And I told that mom, "She is a child. This is her own kind."

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At the time I was still performing. There was a burgeoning market for mom comedy, so I just kept writing about new-mom things, never about what my personal challenges were.

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I landed an audition for a mom TV comedy in Los Angeles. I went. The audition was fine. But as I was walking out, I heard the other mom comics having a conversation.

One said, "I mean, you know my kid's a little retarded, right?" They all laughed.

She said, "I mean, you've seen her, right? You have to admit she's a little bit Downsy."

My heart broke into a million pieces, but I didn't put the comics in their place. I made an excuse. I told myself that sometimes comedians say really nasty things (like that time a comedian said to me, "Aren't you too old to be pregnant? Isn't your baby gonna be retarded?").

Back at home my loneliness consumed me, and it turned to anger. Anger at family members who lived a mile away from me, but were never around. At friends who disappeared. At friends who were there, but acted as if everything was fine. I was angry at anyone who had a typical child, or a typical baby, or anybody who was pregnant and joyful.

My anger turned to despair; I was completely hopeless. Doing the right thing for the baby was my only motivation, and I went from activity to activity like a zombie.

I felt that I couldn't be the mother that she needed me to be, and be a good wife to Jayme. I told him that I wished I could move out. But really, I wished I would just die, so they could find someone better.

Then some friends invited us to vacation with them in Key West, with friends of theirs. It was all couples, with no children. I was very worried about being the one to bring the kid to the party, especially our child.

I didn't know what the couples had heard about her. I didn't know what they would think of her. I had no idea what to expect.

I gravitated to one woman in particular, and over the course of seven days, I told her everything. I told her how I was afraid that I wasn't doing enough for the baby and that I

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would never be able to do enough for her.

She didn't judge me. She didn't say, "Well, at least .." or "It could be worse .... " She just listened. She said that things were going to be however they were going to be-because of us and in spite of us. And that was such a relief to hear her say. She lifted a weight off my soul.

On the last day, the baby played with everyone. She threw her beach ball, and they'd catch it, and everyone would cheer. They said this was the best day of the vacation.

I had watched them get to know her, and I watched her through their eyes. She was hilarious. She was fun, she was warm, she was smart, and she definitely did things when she wanted to. She was our Lulu. Our light, and our hope.

And once I stopped fearing being this kind of mom, I realized that all moms cry a lot. All moms doubt their ability to raise [a] child. All moms worry about the future.

I used to wish I could go back in time and get that test after all, but now I wish I could go back in time and allow myself to feel the joy that a new mother feels. Because that's what I was.

We still go to our music classes, and we still go to our playgroups and the museums, with typical kids. And we go to places just for kids with Down syndrome, too.

After our long days filled with fun, we come back to the apartment. When I put my key in the door, Lulu always says, "Home, Mama." And I say, "Yes, Lulu. We are home."

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